SAT / STRATEGY / FREE GUIDE

SAT Test-Day Strategy Guide

A calm, useful plan for preparation, pacing, and the moments you get stuck.

By TestPrepUnraveled • Updated September 12, 2026 • 5 min read

Prepare your setup ahead of time

Use the official College Board instructions for your test administration to check identification, admission information, permitted items, and device readiness. Open Bluebook ahead of time and complete the required setup. Requirements can change, so use the official checklist rather than treating this guide as an admission policy.

Practice with the tools you will use

The digital SAT uses Bluebook and includes a built-in Desmos calculator for Math. Rehearse with the calculator, answer elimination, and review tools during official practice. Learn how to mark a question and return to it within the current module.

Use a repeatable pacing decision

When stuck, identify the missing step. If you still have no useful next move, choose your best answer, mark the question, and continue. Return while the current module remains open. Do not plan to return to an earlier module after its time ends.

Review with purpose

Check unanswered questions first. Next, revisit marked questions where you can name a specific issue. Re-read the requested quantity in math and verify the evidence in reading. Change an answer when you have a reason, rather than because it feels unfamiliar.

YOUR DESK-SIDE REFERENCE

Quick reference

When	Action	Purpose
Several days before	Check official requirements and device setup	Avoid preventable problems
During practice	Use Bluebook tools	Make the interface familiar
When stuck	Choose, mark, and move	Protect time for other questions
Before the module ends	Review unanswered and marked items	Catch omissions and clear mistakes

Original worked example

You have spent a while on a math question and keep repeating the same calculation. What should you do?

Write down what the question asks, eliminate any impossible answers, choose your best remaining answer, and mark it. Move on and return within the module if time remains.

A tip worth keeping

Build your pacing plan from your own timed practice. A universal seconds-per-question rule will not fit every problem.

Your quick checklist

- Identify the exact task before working.
- Show the reasoning, not just the answer.
- Review the mistake and try a new example.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

Try it yourself

These original questions were written for this guide. Try each one before reading the answer key.

1. Should you count on returning to a question in a finished module?

2. You find that you solved for x, but the question asks for 2x. What is the best review habit?

3. Where should you verify what to bring?

Answers & explanations

1. No. Finish review before that module closes.

2. Underline or restate the requested quantity before calculating and check it again before submitting.

3. The official College Board checklist for your specific test administration.

Keep your prep current

Check your test provider for current rules and format details. These are independent sample guides and contain no official test questions.

Official Bluebook testing tools

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